

BARCLAYS × GRADUATE CAMPAIGN
2026

Receipt of Reality.

Adulthood adds up. Barclays helps.

An integrated campaign to acquire 10,000 new Higher Education Account customers in six months.

Make Barclays the bank graduates choose.

THE OBJECTIVE

10,000

new Higher Education Account customers across a six-month window.

THE BUDGET

£500k

to be spent across a fully integrated, online + offline campaign.

THE AUDIENCE

1.04m

UK graduates per year — over 18, UK-based, finished within 3 years.

The task: reposition a 335-year-old bank for a generation that has never written a cheque.

Graduates are the most commercially valuable acquisition window in retail banking — they are forming lifelong financial habits, credit histories and mortgage potential. Win them now, keep them for life.

335 years old. Forever new.

Barclays is built on firsts.

- 1967** Launched the world's first ATM at Enfield.
- 1986** Issued the UK's first debit card.
- 2007** Pioneered UK contactless payments.
- 2012** Launched Pingit — the first peer-to-peer mobile payment app.

BRAND TENSION

**A heritage that
feels heavy —
in a market that
feels fast.**

OUR JOB

Translate that heritage into the cultural language graduates use today — without losing the seriousness people trust Barclays for.

Graduates aren't anti-bank. They're anti-friction.

45%

of UK students
don't open a student account

They go straight to Monzo, Chase or Revolut — bypassing the traditional student-to-graduate funnel entirely.

89%

of Gen Z prefer
app-first banking

Onboarding speed, design and clarity now outrank brand heritage as the deciding factor for switching.

£0

marginal switching cost
in under 7 days

The Current Account Switch Service has removed friction — meaning loyalty has to be earned every day.

Sources: Money Saving Expert Student Bank Survey 2024; FCA Financial Lives 2024; Pay.UK CASS Q4 2025 dashboard.

Real graduates. Real pressures.

1.04m

UK higher-education
qualifications awarded in
2024/25.

HESA, JAN 2026

£32,000

median graduate starting
salary in the UK (2024).

HESA GRADUATE
OUTCOMES

75%

of UK adults used mobile
banking in 2024 — mobile is
now the default.

UK FINANCE, 2025

£1,373

average UK rent (Mar 2026)
— up 16% on three years
ago.

ONS PRIVATE RENTAL
INDEX

We aren't fighting other banks. We're fighting tabs.

Graduates compare Barclays to whatever sits next to it on their home screen.

BEST FOR GRADUATES				
FEATURE	BARCLAYS	MONZO	CHASE UK	REVOLUT
Overdraft	£1,500 free	£2,000 limit	—	—
Cashback	Up to 15%	—	1% on debit	Tiered plans
Switching incentive	£175	—	—	—
In-app insights	Yes	Strong	Strong	Strong
Brand age	335 yrs	10 yrs	5 yrs (UK)	11 yrs

The win-condition isn't features — it's relevance.

Three graduate mindsets. One product fit.

01

The Newly Independent Starter

21–24 • first job/job hunt • city or commuter belt

Needs cash flow, clarity and a safety net.
Highest urgency, highest switching relevance.

PRIORITY

02

The Socially Fluent App-Banker

22–26 • digital native • splits bills via Monzo

Comfortable banking on a phone. Needs proof
Barclays is modern, not corporate.

REFRAME

03

The Progress Planner

23–27 • stable income • thinks long-term

Cares about rewards, savings and a bank that
can grow with them.

RETAIN

All three are digitally fluent, financially stretched and reachable through the same channels. Segment 01 leads the campaign.

Meet Maya. 23. Newly graduated. Newly broke.



MAYA OKONKWO

23 · Manchester

Marketing Exec
Graduated July 2025

INCOME	£28k starter
RENT	£900 / mo
BANK	Monzo (default)
MINDSET	Capable, but cash-flow stressed
FEELS	Overwhelmed, under-rewarded

“*I'm earning, I'm working, I'm doing everything I was told to do. But somehow, I still finish the month £200 short. Nobody told me adult life would feel like one long direct debit.*”

WHAT SHE NEEDS FROM A BANK

- Breathing room when payday is a week away.
- Tangible rewards she can actually use — not points she'll forget.
- A brand that talks to her, not at her.
- An app that doesn't feel like 1998.

After 12 hours of desk research and 18 Reddit threads later...

Graduation is sold as freedom. The reality feels like admin.

"You'll find your feet."

But the feet are very expensive.

"You'll figure it out."

But everything wants a direct debit.

"You're so lucky."

But the cost-of-living index disagrees.

Strategic implication: Barclays shouldn't sell the dream. It should fund the reality.

From product features to financial empathy.

01

PROBLEM

Graduates feel emotionally and financially stretched.

Banks read as cold, transactional, irrelevant.

02

PROPOSITION

Barclays understands the reality of post-uni life — and rewards it.

Reframing product features as practical, real-world support.

03

BEHAVIOUR

Reappraise → Compare → Click → Start switch → Complete switch.

Move the audience from 'a bank for my parents' to 'a bank for my life now.'

STRATEGIC PROPOSITION · *Adulting adds up. Barclays helps.*

RECEIPT OF REALITY.

A creative platform that turns the unspoken pressures of post-uni life into a single, instantly recognisable visual: a receipt that keeps printing.

Endline: "Reality adds up. So does Barclays."

REAL ADULT LIFE	
MAY 2026 · MANCHESTER	
Rent	£900.00
Commute	£183.00
Council tax	£148.00
Meal deals	£76.00
Broadband	£41.00
"Adult" haircut	£35.00
Student loan	£187.00
Therapy app	£12.99
Wedding gift fund	£50.00
Trying to feel okay	Priceless
TOTAL	A LOT.

A visual system. Not just a campaign.

VISUAL

Bird's-eye still life of adult life — rent receipts, commute cards, work shirts, meal deals.

PALETTE

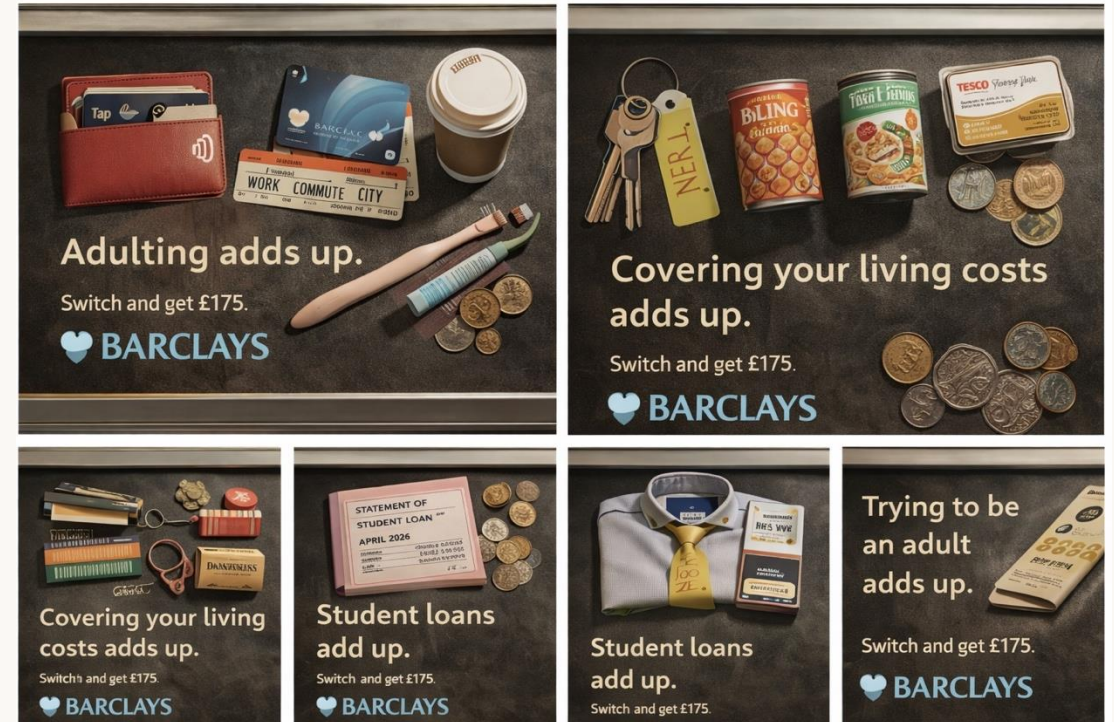
Warm tactile cream + receipt paper + Barclays cyan. Honest, never glossy.

VOICE

Dry, observational, self-aware. Wry — not whinging. Confident — not corporate.

FORMAT

Modular: every execution = a different receipt line item that scales across channels.



ABOVE: Print and social executions from the campaign

The receipt as a hero.

Reality adds up.

Get £175 when you switch to the Barclays Higher Education Account.

HEADLINE

Three words. Earns attention in print, OOH and 6-second cutdown.

COMPOSITION

Bird's-eye objects + literal till receipt. Reads in any format, any size.

MESSAGE

Honest acknowledgement of cost — paired with a clear, useable benefit.

CTA

“Switch and get £175” — single, measurable, traceable action.

Reality adds up.

Get **£175** when you switch to the Barclays Higher Education Account.

Switch and get £175

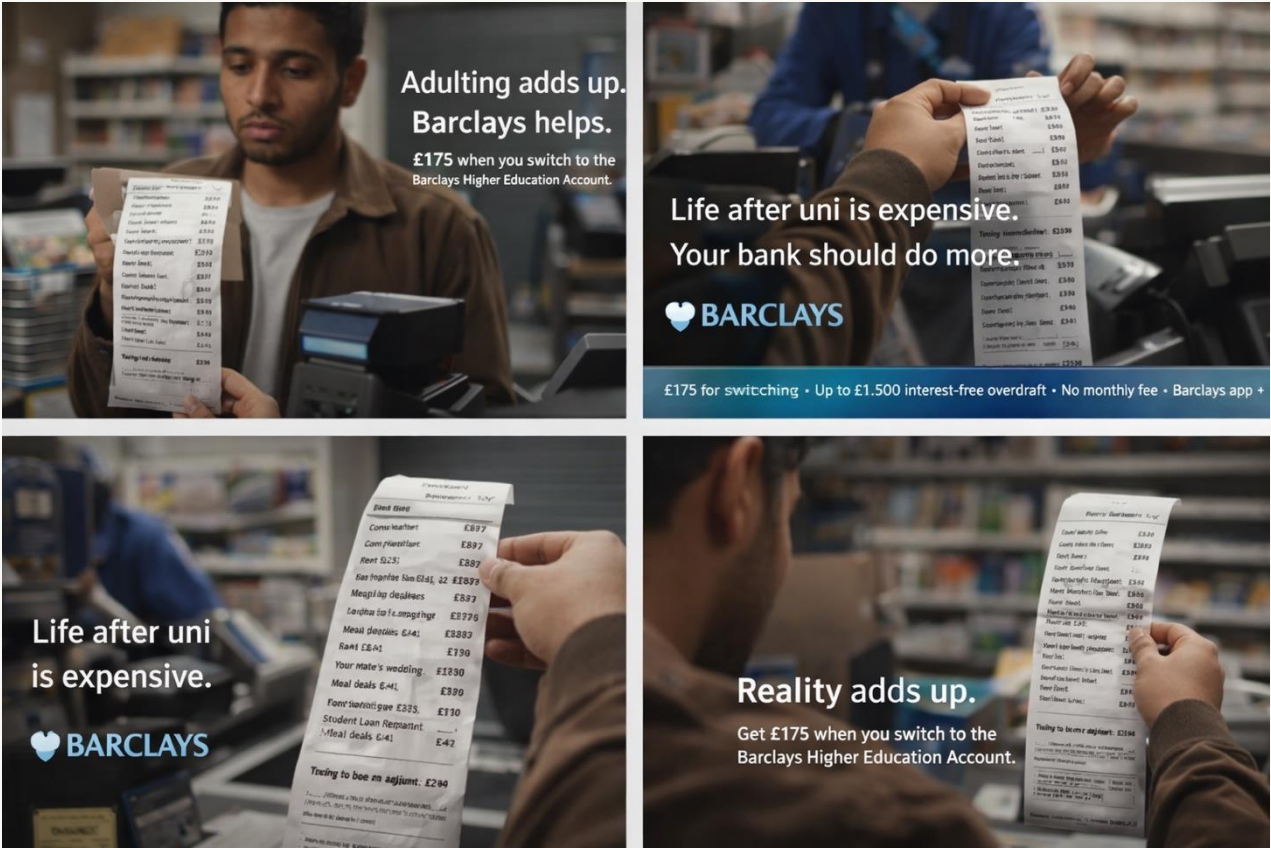
BARCLAYS

- ▶ No monthly fee
- ▶ Up to £1,500 interest-free overdraft
- ▶ Extra cashback with Barclays Blue Rewards

Item	Amount
Rent	£850
Commute	£183
Meal deals	£76
Broadband	£41
You actually pay for water, now:	£49
Job interview shirt	£30
TOTAL	£294

Trying to be an adult:
priceless

One idea. Many executions. Thumb-stopping.



INSTAGRAM + TIKTOK

Six-frame story that ends on the offer.

FORMATS 1:1, 9:16, 4:5

CUTDOWNS 6s, 10s, 15s

CTA Tap to switch

KPI CTR + saves

Each tile is a stand-alone pressure point — and a scroll-stopping setup for the £175 offer.

A film. A tool. A wider campaign world.

HERO FILM (60s + cutdowns)

“Checkout.”

A recent graduate places the contents of post-uni life on a supermarket conveyor belt:
rent demand, train ticket, meal deal, work shirt, wedding invite, student-loan letter.

The cashier scans each one. Deadpan. The receipt prints, and prints, and prints.

Endline appears on the receipt itself:
“Reality adds up. So does Barclays. £175 when you switch.”

ACTIVATIONS + EXTENSIONS

Receipt of Reality generator

A web tool that turns your real spending into a shareable receipt — data captured, opt-in.

DOOH “scrolling till”

Train-station & uni-town billboards that print live receipts during rush hour.

Creator-led duets

Money-and-lifestyle creators react to their own “receipt of reality.”

Podcast reads

Commute-window audio scripts on The News Agents, ShxtsnGigs and Saving Grace.

Find them where they already are.

AWARENESS

Reframe Barclays as culturally current.

- DOOH in uni cities + commuter zones
- TikTok + Instagram Reels
- YouTube pre-roll
- Spotify + podcast reads

CONSIDERATION

Move from “seen it” to “thinking about it.”

- Creator partnerships (micro)
- Receipt of Reality web tool
- Editorial content + earned PR
- Paid social cutdowns

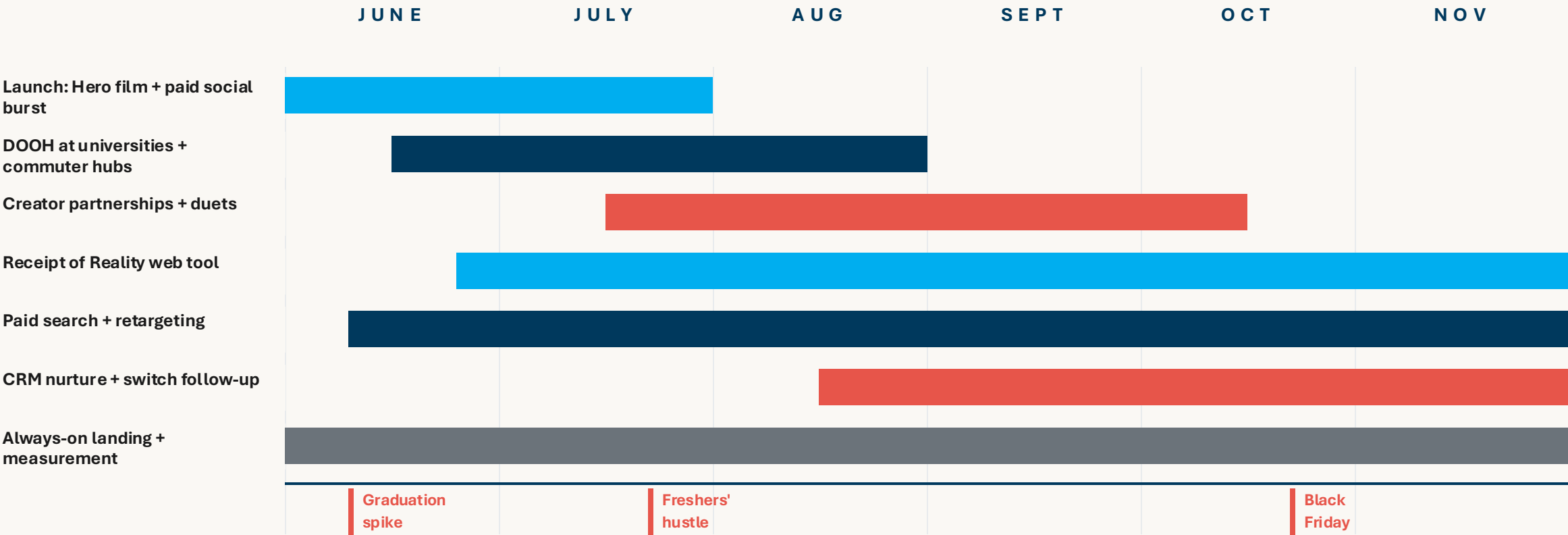
CONVERSION

Reduce friction at the moment of decision.

- Paid search (brand + competitor)
- Retargeting on landing page
- CRM nurture sequence
- On-app referral incentive

Priority cities: London, Manchester, Birmingham, Leeds, Bristol, Glasgow, Edinburgh — covering 62% of UK graduates.

Six months. Built around graduation.



Why these months? June–November captures the full graduate transition: from graduation through first-job onboarding and the most financially stressful Q4 of their adult lives.

£500,000. Spent where it converts.



Paid social (Meta, TikTok, YT)	£150k	Audio + podcast reads	£25k
DOOH + OOH	£85k	Receipt-tool + landing page	£25k
YouTube + online video	£70k	Paid search + retargeting	£20k
Hero film production	£60k	Measurement + optimisation	£10k
Creator partnerships	£45k	Contingency	£10k

TOTAL: £500,000 · FORECAST CPA: ~£50 per acquired customer at 10,000 registrations.

Acquired today. Profitable tomorrow.

10,000

completed switches

8m+

campaign impressions

160k

landing page sessions

20k+

application starts

THE LIFETIME RETURN

**10,000 graduates =
£18m+ lifetime value.**

Average banking lifetime value per customer: ~£1,800 (FCA, 2024).
Cross-sell to credit cards, savings, ISAs and mortgages
compounds that number. The campaign pays for itself in the first
18 months.

WE WILL TEST

£175 vs overdraft message · deadpan vs emotional cuts · creator-native vs polished · CTA copy A/B · city-level response.

Reality adds up. So does Barclays.

WHY THIS CAMPAIGN WINS

- Built on a real graduate tension, not a banking cliché.
- Turns existing Barclays product into emotionally relevant proof.
- Modular creative system — runs across film, social, OOH, audio and digital.
- Targets 10,000 registrations with a forecast CPA of ~£50.